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UNION PANAFRICAINE DES ETUDIANTS
الاتحاد جميع الطلاب الأفريقي
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PAN-AFRICANISM & AFRICAN CULTURE
WORKING GROUP



STUDENTS WITH DISABILITY PROJECT

VICTIM BASED EXPERIENTIAL EVALUATION AND FEEDBACK
DATABASE & REPORT ON INCLUSIVE EDUCATION WITH
FOCUS ON PERSONS WITH DISABILITIES IN BASIC
SCHOOLS IN AFRICA



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Summary

All across Africa, students with disabilities, especially at the basic levels encounter several systemic difficulties. Despite recent successes in increasing accessibility as well as bridging gender inequality gap among in basic education, available evidence suggests that national efforts continue to fall short of providing a wholesome experience for students with disability in basic schools. Students with disabilities are confronted with both institutional and cultural hindrances in the pursuit of education and wholesome education experience. Currently, efforts are addressing these hindrances have largely been focused on the institutional ends (reforms, logistics and infrastructure, etc.). Not much attention is paid to generating feedback from the intended beneficiaries; students with disabilities. Our project is a three-pronged series of activities; a continental feedback-survey of students with disabilities at the basic level, a comprehensive African report based on the feedback of students with disabilities and an extensive media campaign on rethinking approaches to assisting students with disabilities in Africa. The goal is to provide the largest evaluation of policies on inclusive education especially as regards persons with disabilities at the basic level.

The background of the slide features a photograph of a young child with a joyful expression, riding a bright blue bicycle. The child is wearing a light-colored, patterned garment. In the background, another person is partially visible, and a window with a grid pattern allows light to filter through. The overall scene is warm and positive, emphasizing the theme of education and inclusion.

Introduction/Problem Statement

Inclusive education, especially as regards access and holistic experience for persons living with disabilities continues to receive the attention of states, scholars and development partners alike (Ocloo & Subbey 2008; Agbenyega 2007; Ajuwon 2008; Rieser 2012; Elder 2015). The United Nations, UNESCO, World Bank all demonstrate unwavering commitment towards inclusive education especially in developing countries. The 2020 Global Education Monitoring Report draws specific attention to the exclusion of children from school because of “background and ability” (GEM Report, 2020). Key global efforts largely championed by the Millennium Development Goals and more recently the Sustainable Development Goals all point to the growing attempts to expand access and promote quality education with key focus on historically marginalized people including persons with disabilities. According to the World Health Organization, over 150 million children around the world live with disabilities of different forms. Developing countries, many of which are in Africa account for over 80% of this number (WHO, 2011). It gets even more worrying when one considers for instance UNICEF’s estimation in 2014 that over 90% of children with disabilities living in low income countries had no education (UNICEF, 2014).

A background image showing a student in a wheelchair in a classroom setting. The student is wearing a blue shirt and is positioned in the foreground, slightly to the left. The background is blurred, showing other students and classroom furniture.

Specifically for students with disabilities in basic schools, governments and international development partners have rolled out several policy programmes to address their needs. Programmes like the World Bank Disability-inclusion Education in Africa have proven immensely beneficial. Despite these significant inroads, we must still treat the successes with cautious optimism as others like Peters (2003) estimate that only 5% of children with disabilities complete primary education. Psychologists and social workers describe the formative years of human beings as the most important periods in their lives. This is the stage when behavioural traits are developed (Bijou, 1976; Peacock-Chambers, 2017). It is important therefore that children are given the best available irrespective of their physical or cognitive predicaments.

Evidently, attempts both in scholarly and policy spaces to create accessibility for students with disabilities however crucial, barely integrate beneficiary/victim feedback to create solutions that reverberate with intended beneficiaries. Akin to modernisation development thought, policy actors make the mistake of developing strategies, sometimes with the best intentions but still without due consideration for the experiential perspectives of intended beneficiaries.

Our project aims to depart from this orthodoxy, and contribute to deepening our collective understanding of the predicament of students with disabilities in ways that impact policy. The project primarily covers three broad themes; feedback survey of students with disabilities across Africa, a comprehensive report based on the experiential account of students with disabilities, and a media campaign based on the lived

Feedback-survey of students with disabilities in Africa

This is the first of the three part project. Against the background we have provided on conventional approaches and strategies towards inclusion and holistic education experience for students with disabilities in basic schools in Africa, we intend to gather the largest pool of personal accounts or feedback on how students with disabilities interact policies on inclusion in the education sector. For example, what students with disabilities make of specific policies by their respective governments to promote inclusive education. Also, what experiences and feedback students with disabilities at the basic schools have generally. And what new measures would make their experiences in school better and more wholesome. This exercise

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provides AASU, the largest student organization in Africa, an elaborate database of experiences of students with disabilities in basic schools across Africa. This is particularly important to the work of the organization on education and students' rights broadly. The database not only provides AASU with relevant evaluative report from the perspective of students with disabilities in basic schools, it also enriches our understanding of the complexities of the lived experiences of students with disabilities to be able to deal with governments and other development partners better. Through this database, we are able to gain more nuanced and insightful appreciation of the policy gaps on inclusion of students with disabilities in the educational system in Africa. Additionally, it forms an important primary data source for our research into issues of education in Africa.



Comprehensive Report

Derived from the feedback-survey and the database of experiences of students with disabilities in basic schools across Africa, we shall produce a comprehensive report that captures observations across the continent. This will be an evidence based report on the nature of policy interventions for students with disabilities in basic schools in Africa and the feedback of these students with the view to inform future policies or to cause amendments in existing policies. The report would be the first detailed body of work by any student organization in Africa, and moreover one that centers primary accounts and experiences of students with disabilities.

"Media campaigns are important towards re-orienting the larger population against myths and superstitions ."

Media Campaign

The final leg of the project will develop a blueprint for media campaigns across the continent based on the nuanced cultural perspectives shared by students with disabilities. AASU recognizes the need to develop tailor-made media campaigns that fit unique cultural complexities of the several African countries in question. The goal here is to leverage on the insights we shall gain from the feedback-survey to develop media education and sensitization programmes for mass and new media platforms. This will take the form of screen campaigns, news articles, radio adverts, LPMS, etc. Media campaigns are important towards re-orienting the larger population against myths and superstitions that target persons with disabilities. We believe the campaign is much stronger when it is told from the perspective of the victims of such harmful myths and superstitions.



Project Objectives

The project sets out to among other things;

- Compile a database of policies on inclusive education with special focus on persons with disabilities in basic schools in Africa.
- Conduct the largest feedback-survey of persons with disabilities in basic schools on policies on inclusive education in Africa.
- Aggregate lived experiences and accounts of persons with disabilities in basic schools in Africa.
- Assess the extent of success and acceptance of government and international development partners' policies targeted at persons with disabilities in basic schools in Africa.
- Develop a comprehensive report on the experiences of persons with disabilities in basic schools in Africa with the aim to influence policies on inclusive education.
- Develop workable media campaigns told from the perspective of students with disabilities in Africa with the aim to combat harmful myths and superstitions against persons with disabilities.

Prior experience in working with other international organizations

AASU has an extensive history of taking on projects across seven working areas under its mandate.

These include; Education & Students Rights, Gender and Advocacy, Capacity Building, Pan Africanism & Culture, Migration & Labour, Environment & Climate Change, and Democracy and Governance.

Here are a couple of projects; completed and ongoing.

Tuning Africa Project

Completed

The Tuning Africa pilot Project is implemented in the framework of the Joint Africa-EU Strategy - it is a concrete deliverable of the 2014-2017 Roadmap of the 2014 EU-AU Heads of State and Government Summit. The general objective of the project is to contribute and support the harmonization of higher education programmes and the creation of a revitalized, distinctive, attractive and globally competitive African higher education space, through enhanced intra-African collaboration.

Haqaa Initiative

Completed

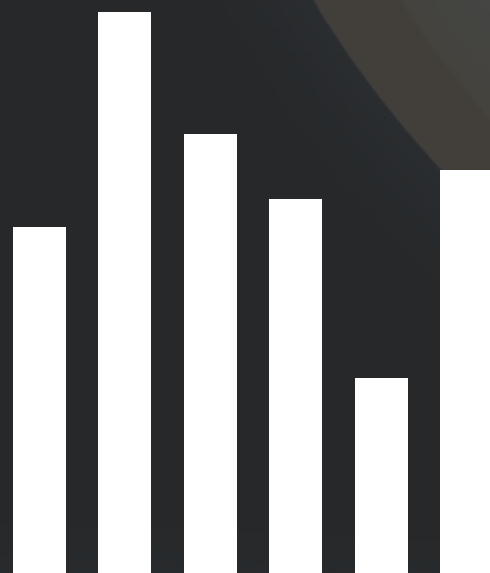
The HAQAA (Harmonization of African Higher Education Quality Assurance and Accreditation) Initiative, funded by the European Union in partnership with the African Union, focuses on the development of a harmonized quality assurance and accreditation system at institutional level, national, regional and Pan-African continental level. This has included the production of the African Standards and Guidelines for Quality Assurance in Higher Education (ASG-QA), a reference document that provides a common language by which quality in higher education is assessed and quality procedures are conducted in higher education in Africa.



Key activities to be implemented

- Desk review of government policies that target persons with disabilities in basic schools
- Selection of schools for the project
- Capacity training for country representatives, enumerators and research assistants
- Key interviews and feedback-survey of students with disabilities
- Compilation of report
- Designing media campaign strategies

“Capacity training for country representatives, enumerators and research assistants”



Project end-beneficiaries

The project will be implemented in 10 countries across all 5 regions in Africa; West, East, Central, South, and North. For each region, we shall select two countries. The basic criteria for selection of countries will be based on the vibrancy of local member unions as well as demonstration of capacity to partner AASU for the successful implementation of the project.

For each of the 10 countries, we shall select 50 basic schools. Currently, there is no available data on the number of persons with disabilities in the schools to be considered.

However, where there are special schools, we expect such schools to have an average population of 50 per school.

Ultimately, the following stakeholders stand to benefit directly or indirectly from the project;

- Students with Disabilities
- Special Schools
- Teaching and Non-Teaching Professionals
- Governments
- Education Policy Actors

Describe how your project complements or adds to other similar initiatives.

The project adds to existing knowledge and understanding on inclusive education and non-discrimination policies. It complements these existing policies to the extent of its victim centered feedback effect. Various state and international education policies on accessibility, inclusion and quality would be enriched by the outcomes of the project.

Describe your organization's management structure, governance, and capacity to carry-out projects

Congress is the highest decision making body of the Union with representatives from all member unions across all 54 countries .

Executive Committee is the second highest organ of the Union, and assumes responsibility for the execution of all policies and programmes adopted by the Congress.

Technical Committee is supported by a technical team comprising personnel seconded by the Government of Ghana and locally recruited by the Secretariat to work in the Secretariat.

Geographic location(s) where the project activities will take place.

- West Africa: Ghana and Benin
- East Africa: Kenya and Rwanda
- Central Africa: Cameroon and
- South Africa: South Africa and Zimbabwe
- North Africa: Morocco and Egypt

Thematic area(s) and proposed outline of the Project

The project aligns specifically with the United Nations' Sustainable Development Goal 4. SDG 4 targets aims to ensure inclusive and targeted quality education for all. The United Nations recognizes the essence of education and the need to make it accessible to all without limitations.

The themes under the project include;

- Non-discrimination
- Inclusive education
- Quality Education
- Policymaking

Expected goal and learning objective(s) of the game

The project sets out to among other things;

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Phase One: Feedback-survey of students with disabilities in Africa.

Against the background we have provided on conventional approaches and strategies towards inclusion and holistic education experience for students with disabilities in basic schools in Africa, we intend to gather the largest pool of personal accounts or feedback on how students with disabilities interact with policies on inclusion in the education sector.

Phase Two: Comprehensive Report

The report will be based on the observations from Phase 1. The goal of this report is to compile the experiences and observations of students with disabilities across the

continent into a guiding document that could serve as a useful frame of reference to policy actors.

Phase Three: Media Campaign

The goal here is to leverage on the insights we shall gain from the feedback-survey to develop media education and sensitization programmes for mass and new media platforms.

Outline why your organization is well-suited to undertake the proposed project.

AASU already has grassroots mobilizing capacity with membership cutting across student groups on the Continent at the national and regional levels. As the largest organization of students across the Continent, AASU serves as the lead body of energetic and intellectual young leaders of the Continent. The Union has presence in 54 African countries with commitment of student unions and state governments alike. In the past AASU has played critical roles in different causes on the continent including the fight against apartheid in South Africa. Critical to our success is the fact that our membership comprises most students and young people in Africa and the diaspora. This Union is considered the first choice for consultation and partnership on issues affecting students and young people in Africa.

Endorsements

- African Union
- Global Students Forum
- The Kaylash Satyarti Foundation
- 54 National Student Unions in Africa

Key Personnel involved in the project

Dr. Kaylash Satyarti (Kaylash Satyarti Children's Foundation)

Sebastien Berger (Global Students Forum)

Monitoring and evaluation provisions

AASU has a functioning internal Monitoring and Evaluation Team led by a competent Officer with significant experience in managing projects in Africa. The M&E Team works closely with the Internal Audit Team to provide critical review and assessment of all AASU projects.

Additionally, AASU operates under the Ministry of Foreign Affairs and Regional Integration of Ghana, and is subject to the independent external audits of the Government of Ghana.

We shall employ these tools to conduct the evaluation:

- Social Return on Investment (SROI)
- Basic Efficiency Resource Analysis (BER analysis)

Sustainability Plan

The outcomes of the project could be sustained for a considerable amount of time post implementation. After the First Phase, the database could become a useful source of data for further research on issues of inclusive education and educational policy broadly. Also, the media campaign aspect of the project could also be sustained after the project.

Timelines

Timelines	Activities	
Quarter 1 Oct – Dec 2021	Feedback-survey of students with disabilities in Africa Desk review of government policies that target persons with disabilities in basic schools Capacity training for country representatives, enumerators and research assistants Key interviews and feedback-survey of students with disabilities	
Quarter 2 Jan – Mar 2022	Compilation of responses and observation into a comprehensive report.	
Quarter 3 Apr – Jun 2022	Developing and rolling out a media campaign strategy based on the accounts, lived experiences and feedback of students with disabilities in basic schools in Africa.	

Budget

	Description of Work	Start and End Dates	Cost (\$)
Phase One			
Phase Two			
Phase Three			
Total			

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